Chapter Seven

Questions of Authority

Between 1135 and 1160, Peter Abelard shows the power of Aristotelian logic, and systematic theology is born

SOMETIME AROUND 1135, the theologian Peter Abelard put the final touches on his latest project: the *Theologia Scholarium*, a treatise on the nature of God.

He had been polishing and revising the *Theologia* for fourteen years, ever since the first version of the book had been condemned as dangerous error. Back then, Abelard had been forced by a church council in Soissons to throw his book into a bonfire with his own hands. Now he hoped to defend his orthodoxy.

Instead, he would find himself facing yet another church council; and this time, the punishment would be more extreme.

For over forty years, Abelard had lived and breathed language. He had spent his teens studying the works of Aristotle in Paris and sharpening his skill with words: “I preferred the weapons of dialectic to all other teachings of philosophy,” Abelard wrote, of his own early years, “and armed with these I chose the conflicts of disputation instead of the trophies of war.” In 1102, still only in his early twenties, he set up his own school in the French town of Melun. He taught and wrote, debated and argued; and his fame as a master of logic grew. By 1114, he had become master of the cathedral school at Notre